

Data Retention Standard

Version 2.0 - Effective 1 March 2025

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This standard states how long Northwind Cartography keeps each class of record, who is accountable for the deletion of that class, and how the deletion is evidenced. It applies to production systems, analytics warehouses, backups and third-party processors. It replaces version 1.6 of 12 June 2023, which did not cover the analytics warehouse.

Principles

- Collect the minimum. A field that is not collected does not have to be retained, protected or deleted.
- Retain for a stated purpose. Every retention period in this standard names the purpose that justifies it.
- Delete on a schedule, not on request. Deletion is automated so that it happens whether or not anyone remembers.
- Prove it. Each deletion run writes an evidence record that is itself retained for three years.

Retention periods in this standard are maximums. A team may hold a record for less time than the maximum, and several do, but no team may hold a record for longer without an approved legal hold.

Accountability

The Data Governance Lead owns this standard. Each retention class has a named accountable team, listed in the schedule on page 2. The security team audits a sample of deletions each quarter and reports the result to the risk committee, which meets on the second Tuesday of February, May, August and November.

Retention Schedule

The periods below are measured from the date the record was created, except for employee records, which are measured from the termination date. Every period is a maximum and every class is purged by the monthly job described on page 3.

Customer and product records

- Customer support transcripts are retained for 400 days. Accountable team: Customer Operations.
- Atlas API access logs are retained for 90 days. Accountable team: Platform Engineering.
- Rendered map tile caches are retained for 30 days. Accountable team: Platform Engineering.
- Geocoding query text is retained for 14 days and is never joined to an account identifier. Accountable team: Platform Engineering.

Security, finance and people records

- Security audit logs are retained for 545 days, which is 18 months. Accountable team: Security.
- Incident postmortem documents are retained for 5 years. Accountable team: Reliability.
- Billing and invoicing records are retained for 7 years to meet tax law. Accountable team: Finance.
- Job applicant records for candidates who are not hired are retained for 24 months. Accountable team: People Operations.
- Employee records are retained for 7 years after the termination date. Accountable team: People Operations.

Backups

Encrypted database backups are retained for 35 days and are then destroyed with the rest of the snapshot. Because a backup may still hold a record that has been deleted from production, a deletion is only certified as complete once the backup window has also elapsed.

Deletion, Holds and Exceptions

The monthly purge

The automated purge job runs on the fifth day of every month at 02:00 UTC. It walks each retention class in the schedule, deletes the records that have passed their maximum period, and writes a signed evidence record giving the class, the row count and the job identifier. A purge that fails is retried once; a second failure pages the Platform Engineering on-call rotation.

Legal holds

A legal hold suspends deletion for the records it names and overrides every period in this standard. Only the General Counsel may place or release a hold, and every open hold is reviewed at the quarterly risk committee meeting. Records under hold are tagged in place rather than copied, so that a released hold returns the records to their normal schedule automatically.

Customer deletion requests

A verified customer request to delete personal data is handled inside the window given in the Information Security Policy and is fulfilled by the same purge machinery, running out of cycle. The requester receives a written confirmation naming each retention class that was cleared and each class that was retained under a legal or tax obligation.

Exceptions

An exception to this standard is requested in Workbench, is approved jointly by the Data Governance Lead and the Chief Information Security Officer, and expires after 180 days. Nine exceptions were open at the end of the 2024 fiscal year and six had been closed by 1 March 2025.

Verification and Reporting

Quarterly sampling

Each quarter the security team draws a sample of 25 records that should have been deleted and confirms that no copy remains in production, in the analytics warehouse, or with a third-party processor. A sample with any surviving record is treated as a control failure and is reported to the risk committee within 10 business days.

Third-party processors

Processors must contractually delete Northwind data within 60 days of the end of the contract and must provide a certificate of destruction. The processor register is reviewed twice a year, in April and October. As of 1 March 2025 Northwind uses 14 processors that handle personal data.

Metrics

- Purge success rate, target 100 percent; the 2024 result was 11 successful runs and 1 retried run.
- Sampling pass rate, target 100 percent; the 2024 result was 4 passes out of 4 quarters.
- Median time to fulfil a customer deletion request, target 10 days; the 2024 median was 6 days.

Related documents

This standard should be read with the Information Security Policy, which sets the deletion request window and the incident classification rules, and with the Incident Response Runbook, which sets the postmortem deadlines for the documents retained under the 5-year class.